

As the top B-schools continue to script several success stories each year, the genesis of many lie in the small towns of India

By Rohit Pithauria

A decade back if someone from a small town had dared to dream of getting a management education, the person would have met with a sneer and been branded a daydreamer. The times are changing and so are the B-schools that are gradually making inroads in the lives of people from small towns. Most of such students are churning out success stories every year. No more are they in the dark ages when they were cocooned in a corner, bereft of proper education and opportunities.

The journey to the coveted educational institutions in any field of academia can trace its roots to a growing awareness and the zeal of these small town achievers to better what they have. Some of the students may come from middle-class families and some from even lesser privileged backgrounds, but what binds them together is their passion to excel. For many, it is the money and the social status that makes management a preferred career. "Several B-schools have gone to small towns, increasing the awareness among the students to choose management as a career. Also, the steep demand for managers in the country in recent years has led to this phenomenon," explains Fr E. Abraham, S.J., director, XLRI, Jamshedpur.

The percentage of small town students in most of the institutes can eas-

ily reach 30 per cent. For most of them, the route to success is fraught with setbacks and hardships, and a gnawing financial crunch hovers permanently. Due to the lack of adequate coaching, Ram Kumar, an IIM student, who hails from Kalyanpur Basti, a small agricultural village in eastern Bihar, couldn't make it to the Indian Institute of Technology. Instead, he joined the Department of Chemical Engineering and Technology, Panjab

University, and decided to support some of his financial needs in order to lessen the burden on his family. "I started taking tuitions so that I could afford the coaching for CAT. It was quite hectic, managing my schedule between the engineering classes, tuitions and CAT preparation. The only thing that kept me motivated was the hardship that my parents had to go through to get me here," he says.

Now various scholarships and loan



Big Dreams COME FROM SMALL TOWNS